

The spoken word

THE SPOKEN WORD IS DIFFERENT FROM WRITTEN LANGUAGE IN MANY KEY RESPECTS.

A person's speech is influenced by various factors, such as where he or she is from and to whom he or she is talking. It's important to consider these factors when writing or analyzing spoken language.

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Standard English

Standard English is often considered the “correct” form of English, because it is grammatically correct and does not use any slang. It is usually spoken in a neutral accent without any regional pronunciation; this is called General American in North America, Received Pronunciation in the UK, and General Australian in Australia. Standard English is used in formal situations, by public officials, and traditionally by the media.

Good evening. Welcome to the nine o'clock news.

Standard English uses formal, unabbreviated vocabulary and correct grammar.



Dialect and accent

Varieties of spoken English have developed in different English-speaking countries across the world, and in the regions and communities within them. Each variety has its own colloquial vocabulary and grammatical constructions. These varieties are known as dialects. An accent is the way in which language is pronounced. People use dialectal words and constructions in informal situations.

Hello, my friend.
How are you?

This person is talking in Standard English, but it sounds odd in an informal situation.

G'day, mate.
How ya goin'?

This is Australian slang for *hello*. It is a contraction of the greeting *good day*.

This is slang for *friend*.

Hey, dude.
What's up?

The words *you* and *going* are spelled like this to show how they are pronounced in Australia.

This is another slang word for *friend*, more commonly used in North America.

REAL WORLD

Soap operas

The actors in television soap operas set in a particular location will use the accents from that place. For example, the actors in the show *Dallas* have Texas accents. This makes the dialogue seem more authentic. If the actors don't speak like this themselves, they have to learn the accent.

